accustomed to the hardships of Russian and East European winters, were completely unprepared to work in tropical conditions exacerbated by the arrival of hurricane season. Statsenko later complained about the timing of missile deployment chosen in Moscow: September and October were months of tropical storms and hurricanes. General Gribkov, one of the planners of the operation, realized how bad the situation was when he came to Cuba in October. “Because of the heat (temperatures reaching 35–40° C and more) and high humidity, the regimental commander decided to change crews every hour,” recalled Gribkov, describing his visit to one of Statsenko’s regiments. “The ground was rocky, and in such conditions engineering equipment was not very efficient, so most of the work was done by hand.”[19]

Despite the unbearable heat and humidity, endless rain, and disease besieging the Soviet combat, General Statsenko ordered Sidorov to get his regiment ready for military duty by October 22, one week ahead of the deadline established by Pliev. Sidorov did his best not to disappoint his commander. “In a brief period,” recalled Sidorov, “in exhausting conditions, the personnel … carried out a huge task: concrete monoliths with anchoring bolts were poured to a meter’s depth beneath the launch pads; storehouses for nuclear warheads were built from prefabricated parts; twelve kilometers of gravel roads were built on site; more than 1,500 blasts of rock formations were carried out; storehouses, mess halls, and housing tents were built and equipped with services.”[20]

The first of Sidorov’s R-12 launchers was combat-ready on October 8, the second on October 12. By October 18, four days before Statsenko’s deadline, the whole regiment was combat-ready. They were prepared to fire their missiles at ten hours’ notice—the time required to deliver nuclear warheads to the launch sites. The first warheads were delivered to Cuba on October 4, when the cargo ship *Indigirka* brought sixty nuclear charges for R-12 and R-14 missiles to Mariel, 40 kilometers west of Havana.[21]

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